

the 1990s, the number of people in the UK with a long-term condition has increased by 50% (Department of Health 2000). The prevalence of long-term conditions is also increasing in other countries (e.g. Australia, Canada, France, Germany, Italy, Japan, the Netherlands, Norway, Sweden, Switzerland, Taiwan, USA) (World Health Organization 2002).

Long-term conditions are a major cause of disability and are a leading cause of death in the UK. The prevalence of long-term conditions is increasing in the UK and in other countries. The prevalence of long-term conditions is also increasing in other countries (e.g. Australia, Canada, France, Germany, Italy, Japan, the Netherlands, Norway, Sweden, Switzerland, Taiwan, USA) (World Health Organization 2002).

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